DISTRICT BOYS BASKETBALL

Strongsville stops St. Edward, 49-47

Buzzer-beater sends Mustangs to regional semis

Jerry Henson
The Chronicle-Telegram

DIVISION I AT MIDVIEW

GRAFTON — If the back door opens in a game of basketball, you'd better take advantage of it.

Top-seeded Strongsville's Nick Skully did take advantage of that opportunity as he passed to teammate Dave Hutter for a buzzer-beating layup as the Mustangs eked out a 49-47 win over second-seeded St. Edward Saturday night in a Division I district championship game at Midview High School.

"I knew we needed a defensive stop," said Skully, who had forced an errant Eagle pass prior to the game-winner. "Since this was a close game, I wanted to take it to them and see what happened, whether we won or went to overtime.

"I started to dribble with about 10 seconds left. Dave's man came out on me and allowed me to get the pass off. Out of the corner of my eye, I saw that Dave was open and said to myself 'please put the ball in.'"

The heroics of the Strongsville senior co-captains give the Mustangs (20-3) their first district championship since 1990, sending them to the regional semifinals Wednesday at Cleveland State. Strongsville will face St. Ignatius in the second game of a doubleheader.

The Wildcats handed the Pioneer Conference champions one of their three losses early in the season.

"The sequence for the winning play was designed for Nick to penetrate and read the situation," said Strongsville coach Joe Lynch. "He's great with the ball and makes great decisions. I've got a lot of confidence in him."

St. Edward coach Eric Flannery took the blame for the loss.

"Actually, I take the blame for the turnover," said Flannery. "We tried to get the ball inside to Jawad (Williams). Their defender stepped into the passing lane and forced the bad pass."

Hutter and Dan Bokar led the champions with 13 points apiece, with Bokar coming off the bench to drain three of the team's five 3-pointers. Skully joined them in double figures with 10 points.

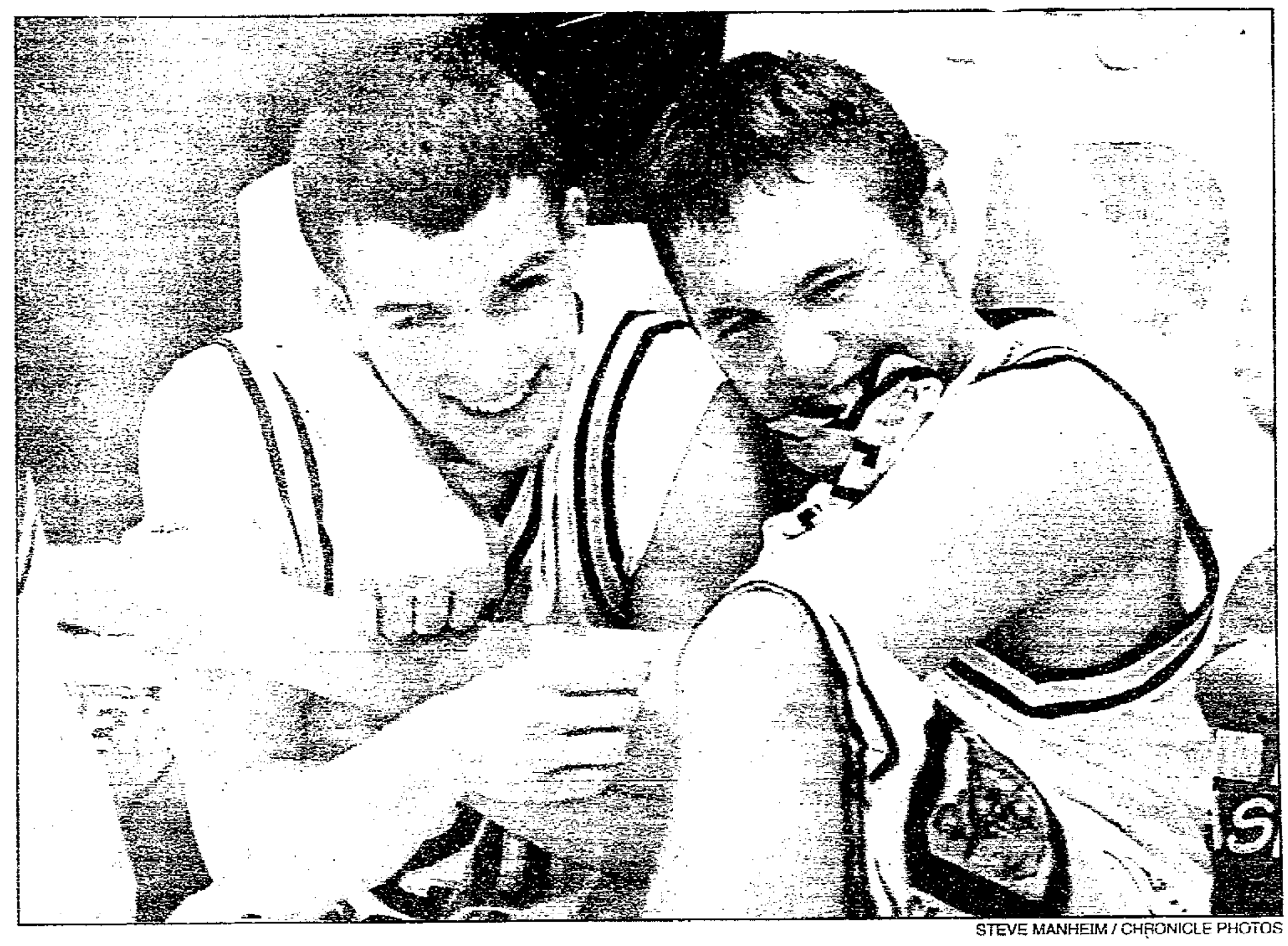
Williams and Jim Kilbane each had 12 points for the Eagles (15-8), and teammate Matt Hollimon finished with 10 points.

ST. EDWARD (47): Petn 0-0-0, Smith 0-0-0, Frommeagie 0-0-0, Kanter 0-0-0, Farrell 0-0-0, Clancy 1-1-3, Braciac 1-0-2, Kilbane 5-2-12, Hollimon 4-1-10, Jonkony 0-0-0, Keenan 1-0-2, Carney 1-1-4, Williams 5-2-12, Green 1-0-2. **Totals 19-7-47.**

STRONGSVILLE (49): Butkin 0-0-0, Pack 0-0-0, Skully 4-1-10, Phillips 0-0-0, Hutter 4-4-13, Bokar 5-0-13, White 0-0-0, E. Koncz 0-0-0, Moehring 2-4-8, Ritter 0-0-0, Bossman 0-0-0, Shearer 0-0-0, Tomsheck 2-1-5, Panaszewicz 0-0-0, K. Koncz 0-0-0. **Totals 17-10-49.**

St. Edward	11	15	9	12	—	47
Strongsville	12	10	16	11	—	49

Three-point goals: St. Edward 2 (Hollimon, Carney), Strongsville 5 (Skully, Hutter, Bokar 3).



JUST GIDDY: Olmsted Falls players Tim Braddick (left) and Garry Reitler celebrate their win over Avon Lake on Saturday.

STEVE MANHEIM / CHRONICLE PHOTOS

FALLS

From D1

Shoremen in front 15-7. The tempo was what they wanted. Their defense was outstanding — first a packed-in zone and later a box-and-one that was very effective — and Port seemed to be on every rebound.

"First quarter (Avon Lake) came out in a zone," said Bulldog coach Pat Donahue. "They did a great job packing it in. We knew they'd be in that. They did a great job with it. We couldn't get anything inside."

"We wanted a lower scoring game," Olinger said. "We did an excellent job rebounding against them and making sure they only had one opportunity on offense against us."

But Gansey scored a dozen points the second quarter and Falls had a one-point lead at intermission.

"Fortunately, Garry (Reitler) was able to hit the three 3s," said Donahue, "and Mike (Gansey) started to heat it up a little bit. They went to a box-and-one and did an outstanding job with that.

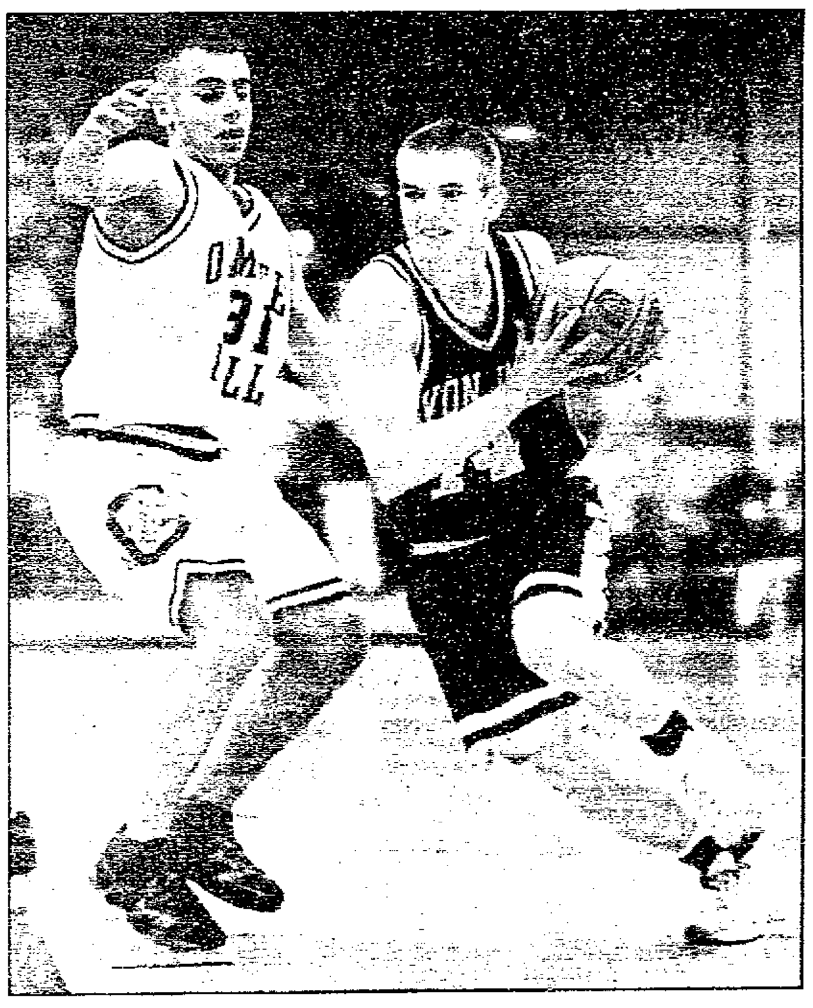
"It surprised me they didn't come back to that the second half. We figured if we could get them to the point where they had to play us man-to-man, we would be in good shape."

Olmsted Falls' press — while on the surface not nearly as effective as Elyria Catholic's was on Thursday — did force Avon Lake to use Port in the back court to bring the ball up the second half. It seemed to change the complexion of the game.

"We don't like to," said Olinger when asked about Port's role in the press-breaker. "We like him back there to break the press but we like to have him under the basket to rebound too and to finish. We didn't get into our offense very well the second half."

"For whatever reason, we can't pressure those people," said Donahue. "Tom Port has killed us. He takes it right down the middle and scores. We just wanted to play a containing press, don't gamble on it.

"Those were the adjustments we made and it caused them some problems and it helped us create the tempo that we probably needed to win the game."



BOWING OUT: Avon Lake's Brian Ingleright moves past Falls' Armando Flores. The Shoremen's season ends at 20-4.

Port did get a couple coast-to-coast baskets off the press, but his presence underneath was not nearly what it was earlier. With Gansey adding eight more points in the third quarter, the Bulldogs shot out to a 39-32 lead entering the final period.

Falls quickly extended the lead to 46-36 with just under four minutes left on a pair of Neal Saluja free throws and maintained a safe margin from there.

Falls was 15 of 21 from the line over the final eight minutes and scored the game's last 10 points to pad the final margin.

The Bulldogs' half-court defense was outstanding. Avon Lake's Brian Ingleright has destroyed teams with his uncanny outside ability, but he had only one 3-pointer Saturday and 13 points total. Either Joe Stanton or Saluja had a hand in his face all night.

"The kids take pride in it," said Donahue of his team's defensive effort. "This team may play better together than any team I've had — both defensively and offensively. This team can put it both together."

"Overall, we had a good year," Olinger said. "Pretty happy with the way the year went. Not real happy with the way the game went."

AVON LAKE (47): Ingleright 5-2-13, Mitchell 1-0-3, Booher 4-0-9, Curry 0-1-1, Port 9-1-21, Day 0-0-0, Morton 0-0-0, Jungermann 0-0-0. **Totals 19-4-47.**

OLMSTED FALLS (64): M. Gansey 12-4-30, Stanton 2-0-4, Reitler 3-2-11, Flores 3-4-10, Saluja 1-5-7, Tenbeek 0-0-0, Ancun 0-0-0, S. Gansey 0-2-2. **Totals 21-17-64.**

Avon Lake	13	11	8	15	—	47
Olmsted Falls	7	18	14	25	—	64

Three-point goals: Avon Lake 5 (Port 2, Mitchell, Ingleright, Booher), Olmsted Falls 5 (Reitler 3, M. Gansey 2).

Rebounds: Avon Lake 30 (Port 15), Olmsted Falls 23 (M. Gansey 10). **Turnovers:** Avon Lake 13, Olmsted Falls 10. **Assists:** Avon Lake 8 (Port, Ingleright 3), Olmsted Falls 16 (Saluja 8). **Team Fouls:** Avon Lake 20, Olmsted Falls 14. **Fouled Out:** Booher, Ingleright (AL).

Indians club 3 homers in win over Lima, Astros

The Associated Press

MORE BASEBALL, Page E1

VALENCIA, Venezuela — The Indians were more than happy to continue Jose Lima's struggles.

Jim Thome, Russell Branyan and Juan Gonzalez each homered for the Indians on Saturday in a 7-6 win over the Houston Astros in an exhibition game.

Lima, who gave up 48 home runs last season, allowed six hits and the three homers in four innings. Thome hit a two-run homer in the first inning, followed by Branyan in the second and Gonzalez in the third.

Lima gave up another run in the first inning on a wild pitch.

Glen Barker drove in Lance Berkman with a sacrifice fly in the eighth to give the Astros their only lead at 6-5. Houston pinch-hitter Carlos Maldonado tied it 5-all with a sacrifice fly earlier in the inning.

But Cleveland's Karim Garcia answered with an RBI triple in the top of the ninth, and Terrell Lowery drove in Garcia with a double to make it 7-6.

Martin Vargas pitched a scoreless ninth for the save.

Cleveland starter Steve Woodard worked three innings, striking out three. He allowed one hit and Richard Hidalgo's sacrifice fly.

Moises Alou had an RBI double in the fourth for Houston, and Jeff Bagwell hit an RBI double in the sixth.

Hometown hero Hidalgo tripled to left off Jake Westbrook in the seventh, and pinch-runner Barker scored on single by Charlie Hayes to make it 5-4.

Venezuelan left-hander Carlos Hernandez worked two scoreless innings for the Astros before 15,162 fans in this western Venezuelan city.

Cleveland pitcher Dave Burba will start against Houston's Wade Miller today in the second game of this two-game Venezuela series.

VIZQUEL

From D1

son defensively.

He tied the AL record for the most consecutive errorless games by a shortstop (95), made just three errors in 156 games and won his eighth straight Gold Glove.

"I have no doubt," Aparicio pronounced, "that he will make the Hall of Fame."

With street vendors selling "Vizquel" sweatbands on the streets of this industrial, high desert city, Valencians were celebrating the chance to see their major league heroes. Children escorted by their mothers brushed past reporters to get autographs from the star shortstops of three generations.

Aparicio, the former Chicago White Sox star, and Concepcion, who played for Cincinnati's Big Red Machine, were honorary captains for the American and National league teams.

They drew deafening standing ovations as they trotted to home plate: a beaming Concepcion wearing his No. 13 Reds uniform, Aparacio tipping his hat and wearing his No. 11 White Sox uniform.

Vizquel joined Venezuelan singer Ilan Chester in leading the crowd with Venezuela's national anthem, then, with flashbulbs popping from the stands, lit up the crowd with a first-inning single off Jose Lima.

The game-opening ball was to be sent to exhibition games in Latin America and other countries before making its way to this year's All-Star game in Seattle — part of a campaign by major league baseball to promote the game abroad, and recognize the accomplishments of the dozens of foreign-born players who have made this a global game.

"At this table, we have three of the best infielders in history," proclaimed Ruben Mijares, a well-known broadcaster.

Also present was Venezuela's latest hero, Astros outfielder Richard Hidalgo.

Hidalgo played in all but nine games last season and hit .314, had 122 RBIs and 44 home runs. Despite pain in his right leg, Hidalgo said he'd taken two days off so he could play the weekend series before a home crowd.

"I'm still learning," the 25-year-old said. "I'm always preparing at home and away to hit it out of the park."

Valencia, home to the winter league Magallanes Navigators, a Venezuelan favorite, refurbished Jose Bernardo Perez Stadium for the series.

DOLAN

From D1

record sellout streak.

Can you say, "Dick, do you want your team back?"

But through it all, Dolan, whose interest in the Indians comes from far more than a business perspective, has kept a positive outlook. How many guys get to own the team they cheered for as a kid?

On his first season as owner:

"I learned that winning 90 games isn't enough. My heart is still beating from the way things ended last year. It was an awakening at times but it was something I thoroughly enjoyed."

On the sellout streak likely coming to an end during his regime:

"There are multiple reasons for it and I couldn't begin to give it any definition. It was inevitable. I'll tell you this though. We have 14 games in April. If we could've opened the season on the road and come back in the middle of April, we probably wouldn't be talking about it right now."

On the significance of the streak:

"It's a streak that should be acknowledged with the same reverence as Joe DiMaggio's (major-league record) hitting streak. We may have experienced a once in a lifetime event."

On maintaining the 3 million-mark in attendance for the sixth straight season:

"All Clevelanders should feel proud of that milestone. The three-million mark in attendance puts Cleveland on the map as a premier baseball city. We now have the best of both worlds — great advance sales with ticket availability. We need to change the mindset that we are sold out."

On paying Juan Gonzalez $10 million for what could amount to one season:

"It's not something you agonize over. You take a look at what the ball team needs. There's some risk involved in doing these things but we felt the ball team needed more offense. Once we came to that conclusion, it was 'Go ahead and get him.'"

On the possibility of a labor stoppage and baseball's rising salaries:

"The only answer I can offer to that is no comment and I hope the other owners do the same thing. But I can't imagine it continuing at this pace. I hope the rest of the owners have enough sense to realize that."

On this year's unbalanced schedule, in which teams play within their own division more often:

"I like it. The Central Division championship is our ticket to the playoffs. If we're going to win the Central Division championship, we have to beat those teams."

On interleague play:

"From a Cleveland Indians perspective, I'd rather not see it, but from a baseball perspective, I would. But I'd like to see a little more interleague play. I want to see Los Angeles and San Francisco come here. I'm sorry to the purists, but I'm not so sure I'm not in favor of getting rid of the American League and the National League as distinctions and playing true rivals like Pittsburgh and Cincinnati. That's where fan interest could be."

On preventing himself from being too much of a fan:

"It's tough, but I have about eight guys in the organization that suppress the fan in me. But we did lose a game the other day and I thought it was a good game. That was strange."

On the Indians this season:

"If this team stays healthy, it's going to be a great one. We're going to stay competitive."

Chris Assenheimer covers the Indians for The Chronicle-Telegram.

SATURDAY'S SCORES

TOURNAMENT
DIVISION I
Ashland [illegible], Tol. St. [illegible]
Cin. Elder 55, Cin. [illegible]
Cin. Western Hills 67, [illegible]
Cle. Hts. 75, Shaker Hts. [illegible]
Cols. Brookhaven 64, [illegible]
Dublin Coffman [illegible]
Lima Sr. [illegible], Tol. St. [illegible]
Massillon Jackson [illegible]
Mentor [illegible]
Spring. S. [illegible]
Strongsville 49, [illegible] St. Edward 47
Thomas Worthington [illegible] 44, OT
Zanesville 61, Logan 43
DIVISION II
Can. S. [illegible], Can. Cent. Cath. [illegible]
Olmsted Falls 64, Avon Lake 47
Ottawa-Glandorf [illegible]
Portsmouth [illegible]
Tallmadge [illegible]
Warrensville Hts. [illegible], OT
Willard 52, Shelby 41
Youngs. Chaney 44, [illegible]
DIVISION III
Findlay Liberty-Benton 55, [illegible] 43
Haviland Wayne Trace 49, Lima Cent. Cath. 44
Jeromesville Hillsdale 57, W. Salem NW 55
DIVISION IV
Reedsville Eastern 63, Portsmouth Clay 46
Strasburg-Franklin 83, Shadyside 73, OT
Willow Wood Symmes Valley 59, Manchester 55
Worthington Christian [illegible]
45

REGIONAL PAIRINGS

DIVISION I

At Ohio State Fairgrounds Coliseum, Columbus
Dublin Coffman (22-2) vs. Zanesville (19-4), Wednesday, 7 p.m.
Cols. Brookhaven (24-0) vs. Thomas Worthington (20-3), Thursday, 7
Championship: Dublin Coffman-Zanesville winner vs. Cols. Brookhaven-Thomas Worthington winner, Saturday, 7:30
At Xavier University, Cincinnati
Cin. Elder (16-6) vs. Spring. S. (19-5), Thursday, 6:15
Vandalia Butler (20-4) vs. Cin. Western Hills (20-4), Thursday, 8
Championship: Cin. Elder-Spring. S. winner vs. Vandalia Butler-Cin. Western Hills winner, Saturday, 7:30
At University of Toledo
Ashland (19-4) vs. Lima Sr. (18-5), Wednesday, 7
At Cleveland State University
Cle. St. Ignatius (21-2) vs. Strongsville (20-3), Wednesday, 8
At University of Toledo
Championship: Ashland-Lima Sr. winner vs. Cle. St. Ignatius-Strongsville winner, Saturday, 7:30
At University of Akron
Mentor ([illegible]) vs. Stow (19-5), Wednesday, 7
Massillon Jackson (20-3) vs. Cle. Hts. (17-6), Thursday, 7 p.m.
Championship: Mentor-Stow vs. Massillon Jackson-Cle. Hts. winner, Saturday, 7:30

DIVISION II

At Wright State University, Dayton
Cin. Purcell-Marian (16-8) vs. Kettering Alter (21-2), Wednesday, 6:15
Cin. Roger Bacon (17-7) vs. Cols. Mifflin (11-11), Wednesday, 8 p.m.
Championship: Cin. Purcell-Marian-Kettering Alter winner vs. Cin. Roger Bacon-Cols. Mifflin winner, Saturday, [illegible]
At Ohio University, Athens
Cols. E. (14-8) vs. Dover (18-5), Wednesday, 6:15
Cambridge (19-4) vs. Portsmouth (19-4), Wednesday, 8
Championship: Cols. E.-Dover winner vs. Cambridge-Portsmouth winner, Saturday, 7:30
At Bowling Green State University
Willard (22-1) vs. Ottawa-Glandorf (23-1), Wednesday, 7
At Cleveland State University
Olmsted Falls (19-4) vs. Tallmadge (24-0), Wednesday, 6:15
At Bowling Green State University
Championship: Olmsted Falls-Tallmadge winner vs. Willard-Ottawa-Glandorf winner, Saturday, 7:30
At Canton Civic Center
Youngs. Chaney (15-5) vs. Warrensville Hts. (22-1), Wednesday, 6:15 p.m.
Can. S. (19-4) vs. Cortland Lakeview (20-3), Wednesday, 8
Championship: Youngs. Chaney-Warrensville Hts. winner vs. Can. S.-Cortland Lakeview winner, Saturday, 7:30

DIVISION III

At Ohio University, Athens
Chesapeake (23-1) vs. Morral Ridgedale (23-0), Thursday, 6:15
Belpre (21-3) vs. Newcomerstown (18-6), Thursday, 8
Championship: Chesapeake-Morral Ridgedale winner vs. Belpre-Newcomerstown winner, Saturday, 3
At Bowling Green State University
Bucyrus Wynford (19-4) vs. Findlay Liberty-Benton (23-0), Thursday, 6:30 p.m.
Haviland Wayne Trace (22-1) vs. Oberlin (16-7), Thursday, 8:15
Championship: Bucyrus Wynford-Findlay Liberty-Benton winner vs. Haviland Wayne Trace-Oberlin winner, Saturday, 3 p.m.
At Wright State University, Dayton
Middletown Fenwick (19-5) vs. Waynesville (17-7), Thursday, 6:15
Canal Winchester (19-4) vs. Casstown Miami E. (22-2), 8
Championship: Middletown Fenwick-Waynesville winner vs. Canal Winchester-Casstown Miami E. winner
At Canton Field House
Girard (17-6) vs. Cle. VASJ (13-11), Wednesday, 7:30
Akr. SVSM (22-1) vs. Jeromesville Hillsdale (23-0), Thursday, 7:30
Championship: Girard-Cle. VASJ winner vs. SVSM-Jeromesville Hillsdale winner

DIVISION IV

At University of Toledo
Holgate (19-4) vs. Delphos St. John's (19-4), Tuesday, 6:30
McComb (18-6) vs. Old Fort (14-10), Tuesday, 8:15
Championship: Holgate-Delphos St. John's winner vs. McComb-Old Fort winner, Friday, 7:30
At Canton Field House
E. Can. (14-9) vs. Cle. Hts. Lutheran E. (19-4), Tuesday, 6:15
Mogadore (16-8) vs. Strasburg-Franklin (20-4), Tuesday, 8
Championship: E. Can.-Cle. Hts. Lutheran E. winner vs. Mogadore-Strasburg-Franklin winner, Friday, 7:30
At Miami University, Oxford
Botkins (21-3) vs. Maria Stein Marion Local (20-3), Tuesday, 6:15
Tipp City Bethel (19-4) vs. Covington (19-4), Tuesday, 8
Championship: Botkins-Maria Stein Marion Local winner vs. Tipp City Bethel-Covington winner, Friday, 7:30
At Ohio State Fairgrounds Coliseum, Columbus
Worthington Christian (20-4) vs. Mansfield St. Peter's (15-8), Tuesday, 6:15
Willow Wood Symmes Valley (18-5) vs. Reedsville Eastern (20-3), Tuesday, 8
Championship: Worthington Christian-Mansfield St. Peter's winner vs. Willow Wood Symmes Valley-Reedsville Eastern winner, Friday, 7:30 p.m.

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